

30 years of e-mail

The most revolutionary communication tool since Graham Bell's telephone has just turned 30 and like a fine wine, it just gets better. In the 21st century, electronic mail has wormed its way into our lives to the point that we can no longer do without it. From our personal lives to businesses, there isn't a single aspect in between where its influence hasn't been felt.

Today, the popularity and usage of e-mail ranks second after the telephone but the gap between the two is steadily tightening. Per day, an estimated 4 billion e-mail messages flow through electronic ravines and the figures are on the rise. And why not? It's a medium that combines the best of the telephone and postal mail.

Tracing the roots

In 1957, at the height of the Cold War, the Soviet Union scored one against the United States when it successfully put in place the world's first artificial satellite, Sputnik I. To up the ante with the Soviets, the US Department of Defense set up a division dedicated to extreme technology research, ARPA (Advanced Research Projects Agency), which later fashioned ARPANET. For the first time in history, computers were able to exchange information electronically.

In 1971 Ray Thomlinson, a programmer, created history by sending off the world's first piece of electronic mail. The e-mail, was addressed to himself and the body read the message, "QWERTYUIOP" or "testing 1-2-3". Two years later in order to make e-mail easier to use, TCP/IP, the language of the today's Internet was born. Many others have significantly contributed to the evolution and progress of e-mail and the ability to send attachments and graphics are just some of the advancements that hundreds of other developers added in e-mail.

During the computer boom of the 1980s, the infrastructure was in place, set to carry homes and offices into the Internet age of the 1990s. As the growth of PC sales continued to soar, the ban on commercial traffic was lifted in 1991; this in conjunction with the creation of the Web browser was the big bang of the e-commerce age.

Throughout the decade, the Internet continued to witness a dramatic surge in

traffic. Web-based e-mail services capitalised on the opportunity. Hotmail, the most well-known e-mail portal in the world, was later sold to Microsoft for \$400 million in January 1998. The extreme success of Hotmail spurred a trend where competing portals would offer free Web e-mail services to its devoted reader base.

Not a bed of roses

The sheer freedom and flexibility that e-mail offered has made it the number one application used on the Internet. But with the fruits of e-mail also come the pits of invasion. In its early days, e-mail was a very safe means of sending messages since the e-mail itself consisted mostly of text. But once e-mail was capable of carrying attachments, malicious hackers started using it to send viruses, Trojans and worms.

As if this isn't enough to force users to take a cautious approach towards e-mail, things get nastier with the abuse of unsolicited e-mail, spam. Named after the tins of American 'SPiced hAM', for each legitimate message sent across the Net, there seems to be a disproportionately higher amount of spam filled with promises of getting filthy rich, shedding pounds off your waist, and buying fabulous offers that you can't afford to miss.

Commerce takes a twist

The growth of e-mail has had a profound influence on enterprise. Documents, visual designs and just about any piece of business correspondence can be sent instantly, and at much lower costs than overnight delivery services. E-mail has provided a grand replacement for telephone calls in many instances. What's more, as this medium is so informal, one doesn't have to worry about composing grammatically correct words and sentences.

Since there is no paper involved, the storing and retrieval of messages becomes much easier and quicker with less space consumed.

The next generation

There is no doubt that e-mail will remain and continue to grow in terms of usage. But at some point in the near future, other marvels like this will have a similar impact in the way we communicate—one only has to consider the rate at which Short Message Service (SMS) and instant messengers are growing.

